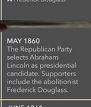


TIMELINE 1776-1860

The Declaration of Independence ■ **The Constitution** ■ Invention of the Cotton Gin ■ **Missouri Compromise** ■ Rise of Abolitionism ■ **War with Mexico** ■ Compromise of 1850 ■ **Uncle Tom's Cabin** ■ Kansas-Nebraska Act ■ **Raid on Harpers Ferry** ■ Election of Lincoln ■ **Secession of South Carolina**

“I believe this government cannot endure permanently, **half slave and half free**. I do not expect the Union to be dissolved ... but I do expect it will cease to be divided.”

ABRAHAM LINCOLN, JUNE 16, 1858

BEFORE 1800	1800-15	1816-30	1831-40	1841-45	1846-50	1851-52	1853-54	1855-56	1857-58	1859	1860
JULY 1776 Declaration of independence proclaims the "self-evident" truth that "all men are created equal." But its main author, Thomas Jefferson, and many other signatories are enslavers.	APRIL 1803 American negotiators agree to the Louisiana Purchase, a treaty to buy the vast Louisiana territory from France. By 1812, slavery is forbidden in northern part of the Louisiana Purchase-land bought from Napoleon.	MARCH 1820 Missouri Compromise: Maine is admitted to the Union as a free state; Missouri will follow as a slave state in 1821. Slavery is forbidden in northern part of the Louisiana Purchase-land bought from Napoleon.	AUGUST 1831 Nat Turner leads a slave rebellion in Virginia. Some 40 whites are killed before the revolt is quashed. Turner is later caught and executed.		APRIL 1854 The Emigrant Aid Society is formed in Massachusetts to help anti-slavery settlers move to Kansas territory to ensure it remains a free territory under the doctrine of "popular sovereignty."	 APRIL 1854 The Kansas-Nebraska Act divides the former Kansas territory into two. The slave or free status of Kansas is uncertain, though it lies north of the line established by the 1820 Missouri Compromise.	MAY 1854 The Kansas-Nebraska Act divides the former Kansas territory into two. The slave or free status of Kansas is uncertain, though it lies north of the line established by the 1820 Missouri Compromise.	JULY 1855 The pro-slavery Kansas legislature begins to enact measures to protect slavery in the territory.	MARCH 1857 In the Dred Scott case, the Supreme Court rules that Congress cannot deprive citizens of their property, including slaves, anywhere in the United States, and that Black people are not citizens.	MARCH 1859 The Supreme Court confirms that the Fugitive Slave Act is constitutional by overturning a Worcester court decision.	
JULY 1787 Congress passes the Northwest Ordinance forbidding slavery in the Northwest Territory-the future states of Ohio, Illinois, Michigan, and Wisconsin.		NOVEMBER 1832 A long-running quarrel between Congress and the states comes to a head when a South Carolina convention adopts a law nullifying federal tariffs and asserting the state's right to secede from the Union-the Nullification Crisis.	JANUARY 1842 Supreme Court rules it unconstitutional to block Fugitive Slave Act. NOVEMBER 1844 James K. Polk narrowly beats Henry Clay in presidential election. Polk favors annexation of Texas and Western expansion.	MAY 1846 Following clashes in Mexican territory between American and Mexican troops, the United States declares war on Mexico.		MAY 1854 The Kansas-Nebraska Act divides the former Kansas territory into two. The slave or free status of Kansas is uncertain, though it lies north of the line established by the 1820 Missouri Compromise.	JULY 1855 The pro-slavery Kansas legislature begins to enact measures to protect slavery in the territory.		MAY 1860 The Republican Party selects Abraham Lincoln as presidential candidate. Supporters include the abolitionist Frederick Douglass.		
SEPTEMBER 1787 The new Constitution permits slavery. SEPTEMBER 1789 In an amendment to the Constitution, an enslaved person counts as three fifths of a white person when assessing Congressional representation.	OCTOBER 1825 Opening of the Erie Canal, which links the Hudson River to the Great Lakes. It is one of many transportation developments that will underpin the North's economic and industrial growth.	MARCH 1833 A political compromise ends the Nullification Crisis, but South Carolina still claims the right to nullify other measures or to secede from the Union.	AUGUST 1846 Mexican troops propose to ban slavery in territories acquired from Mexico. It is passed by the House, but not approved by the Senate. Disputes on slavery deepen.		APRIL 1851 Escaped slave Thomas Sims is arrested in Boston, Massachusetts, under the Fugitive Slave Act and sent back to Georgia. This, and similar cases, cause outrage in the North.	MAY 1854 The Kansas-Nebraska Act divides the former Kansas territory into two. The slave or free status of Kansas is uncertain, though it lies north of the line established by the 1820 Missouri Compromise.	JULY 1855 The pro-slavery Kansas legislature begins to enact measures to protect slavery in the territory.	DECEMBER 1857 The Supreme Court rules that Congress cannot deprive citizens of their property, including slaves, anywhere in the United States, and that Black people are not citizens.	OCTOBER 1859 John Brown leads an attack on the Union arsenal at Harpers Ferry, hoping to inspire a slave rebellion. He is quickly arrested, tried, and executed.	JUNE 1860 The Democratic Party splits into Northern and Southern factions, nominating Stephen Douglas and John Breckinridge as their respective presidential candidates. Constitutional Union Party nominates fourth candidate, John Bell.	
FEBRUARY 1793 Fugitive Slave Act makes it easier for owners to recover escaped slaves. Results in free Black people being sold into slavery.	JANUARY 1808 Under the terms of the Constitution, the importation of slaves into the United States becomes illegal; the internal slave trade continues.	DECEMBER 1833 The American Anti-Slavery Society is founded.	FEBRUARY 1848 Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo ends the War with Mexico. The vast new lands added to the United States will be subject of dispute between pro- and anti-slavery forces.		JUNE 1851 The novel Uncle Tom's Cabin by Harriet Beecher Stowe is published. By the end of 1852, 1.5 million copies of the book have been sold. It permanently changes Northern attitudes to slavery.	JULY 1854 The new Republican Party holds its first convention in Michigan. It opposes the Kansas-Nebraska Act and supports slavery in the territories.	MAY 21 1855 In ongoing violence between pro- and anti-slavery factions in Kansas, pro-slavery men "lynch" the town of Lawrence. A few days later, abolitionist John Brown carries out a retaliatory attack at Pottawatomie Creek.	APRIL 1858 Although Kansas voters reject the Lecompton Constitution, President Buchanan asks Congress to admit Kansas as a state under its terms. Congress calls for a further vote in Kansas.	OCTOBER 1859 John Brown leads an attack on the Union arsenal at Harpers Ferry, hoping to inspire a slave rebellion. He is quickly arrested, tried, and executed.	NOVEMBER-DECEMBER 1860 Lincoln is elected President. In reaction to this, South Carolina holds a state convention that votes for secession on December 20.	
APRIL 1793 Introduction of cotton gin revolutionizes the cotton industry.	JUNE 1812 The United States declares war on Britain, beginning the War of 1812. Fighting continues into 1815.	APRIL 1836 After defeating Mexican forces at the Battle of San Jacinto, Texas confirms its independence and seeks admission to the Union. If it succeeds it will be as a slave state.	JULY 1845 A Texas convention accepts annexation to the United States, despite opposition. Texas is formally admitted to the Union in December.	SEPTEMBER 1850 Congress passes series of measures known as the Compromise of 1850. One hand California is admitted as a free state, but on the other a stricter Fugitive Slave Act is passed.		JULY 1854 The new Republican Party holds its first convention in Michigan. It opposes the Kansas-Nebraska Act and supports slavery in the territories.	MAY 21 1855 In ongoing violence between pro- and anti-slavery factions in Kansas, pro-slavery men "lynch" the town of Lawrence. A few days later, abolitionist John Brown carries out a retaliatory attack at Pottawatomie Creek.	APRIL 1858 Although Kansas voters reject the Lecompton Constitution, President Buchanan asks Congress to admit Kansas as a state under its terms. Congress calls for a further vote in Kansas.	OCTOBER 1859 John Brown leads an attack on the Union arsenal at Harpers Ferry, hoping to inspire a slave rebellion. He is quickly arrested, tried, and executed.	NOVEMBER-DECEMBER 1860 Lincoln is elected President. In reaction to this, South Carolina holds a state convention that votes for secession on December 20.	